

Who do you listen to?

EVERYBODY HAS IDEAS for what you should do with your money. The problem? The quality of this advice is at best unreliable and at worst destructive: Some of it is conflicted, much not relevant to you, and most just plain bad. Sifting through it all is not only time-consuming, but it can also easily derail you from your course.

In the coming chapters, we're going to meet a number of characters: Financial gurus and journalists, fund managers and forecasters. Their advice is often seductive and compelling. In evaluating their words, we have something they did not—the benefit of hindsight. We *know* what happened and how their advice worked out. This gives us an advantage in assessing those claims. The lessons will help you assess people on TV, on social media, or even at a dinner party who want to tell you what you should do with your money.

Spoiler alert: Much of the advice was not good.

The purpose here is not schadenfreude, but to reveal to you just how relentless bad advice is. These are not outliers—they are run-of-the-mill media appearances that can be heard on any given day. Most important of all, none of this “free” advice should ever be the basis of your investment decisions.

There is an endless torrent of media advice. It's an overwhelming firehose of speculation and opinion. Most of it can be safely ignored.

When I see someone confidently declaring why this or that investment is so great—in the media, at a conference, or in published commentary—I maintain a healthy skepticism. I accomplish this by considering the speaker and their advice.

About the advice: